

תְּקִנַּת הַשָּׁבִין

Takanas HaShavin

Introduction

הַקְדָּמָה

The seven praises of teshuvah (Yoma 86) and the seven lower sefiros

פְּתִיחָה

The theme: The whole work hangs on the Gemara's seven statements in praise of teshuvah (Yoma 86). Teshuvah is drawn from the *binah* of the heart — which is why the Men of the Great Assembly fixed it after “binah” in the blessings. The seven praises correspond to the seven lower *sefiros*, the stages by which anything passes from the heart's understanding into completed act; hence seven simanim, one per praise.

In Yoma [86a–b], — **גְּדוּלַּת הַתְּשׁוּבָה** “כו', עֵינֵי נֶשֶׁם שֶׁבַע מִמְדּוֹת בְּגִדְלָת וּמַעֲלָת הַתְּשׁוּבָה” **“Great is teshuvah,” etc. — see there seven** statements on the greatness and elevation of teshuvah.** ³²¹ **And it is known that teshuvah is drawn from** — **וְיָדוּעַ דִּהְיָתְשׁוּבָה נִמְשָׁךְ מִהַבִּינָה שֶׁבִּלְבָב**** **the *binah* [understanding] of the heart** **as it says, “and his heart shall understand and he shall return”** — **וְיָבִינָה, כְּמוֹ שֶׁאָמְרוּ בְּמִגִּילָה [יז:]** **“Yeshayah 6:10”⁴; therefore we say [the blessing of] “teshuvah” after “binah” [in the Amidah],**

1 Yoma 86a–b: Seven statements in praise of teshuvah: (a) “Great is teshuvah, for it brings healing to the world”; (b) “Great is teshuvah, for it reaches the Throne of Glory”; (c) “Great is teshuvah, for it overrides a Torah prohibition”; (d) “Great is teshuvah, for it hastens the redemption”; (e) “Great is teshuvah, for it turns willful sins into inadvertent ones — or into merits”; (f) “Great is teshuvah, for it lengthens a person's days and years”; (g) “Great is teshuvah, for one individual who repents, he and the whole world are forgiven.” R' Tzadok reads the seven as corresponding to the seven lower *sefiros*, and structures the work's seven simanim accordingly.

2 Cf. Pesachim 54a (and Nedarim 39b): teshuvah is among the *seven things created before the world* — “Torah, teshuvah, Gan Eden, Gehinnom, the Throne of Glory, the Beis HaMikdash, and the name of Mashiach.” The list itself traces this work's arc: teshuvah (rooted in *Binah*) that reaches *the Throne of Glory* (Siman 2) and culminates in *the name of Mashiach* (Siman 4).

3 R' Tzadok — parallel (Tzidkas HaTzadik §100): “Teshuvah means that one *returns the very thing to Hashem* — that is, he recognizes that Hashem effects everything, and that His power was present even in the *thought* before it was formed in a man's heart (Bereishis Rabbah 9); it emerges that Hashem gave him the strength even within the sin, and through this, after complete teshuvah, he merits that willful sins become merits, for this too was Hashem's will.” This is the inner engine of the “seven greatnesses” the preamble sets out: teshuvah is no mere remorse but the restoring of the strayed thing to its Source — and because the very power spent on the sin was God-given, that power, turned back, becomes the ladder by which teshuvah “reaches the Throne.”

4 Yeshayah 6:10: part of Yeshayah's inaugural vision (ch. 6). After Israel has persisted in sin, the prophet is charged: **“הַשְׁמַן לֵב הָעָם הַזֶּה וְאָזְנוֹי הִכְבֵּד וְעֵינֵי הַשֹּׁעַ, פֶּן יִרְאֶה וְבִעֵינָיו וּבְאָזְנוֹי יִשְׁמַע וּלְבָבוֹ יִבִּין וְשָׁב וְרָפָא לוֹ”** — “Make the heart of this people fat, and their ears heavy, and seal their eyes, lest they see with their eyes and hear with their ears and their heart understand, and they return and be healed.” **Rashi** explains “*hashmen*” as a continuous hardening (of the form “*hachbed es libo*,” Shemos 8:11), and that “lest they see with their eyes and their heart understand and return, and it be their healing” describes the very outcome the people had closed their hearts against. R' Tzadok draws on the order of the verse — first “their heart shall *understand* [*yavin*],” then “and *return* [*va-shav*]” — that teshuvah is drawn from the *binah* of the heart; this is why the Men of the Great Assembly set the blessing of *teshuvah* after *binah* in the Amidah (Megillah 17b), and why the “healing [*ve-rafa lo*]” that follows is the healing of forgiveness.

ונודע ד'שבע מדרגות הם ביציאת דבר לפועל מבינת הלב עד גמר הפעלה,⁵ וכן שבע גדולות אלו דתשובה — **And it is known that there are seven stages in a thing's emergence into act, from the understanding of the heart until the completion of the deed — these being the secret of the seven sefiros Chesed, Gevurah, Tiferes, Netzach, Hod, Yesod, Malchus — and against them is every “seven,” as is known; so too these seven “greatnesses” of teshuvah.**⁶

5 Megillah 17b: “Why did [the Men of the Great Assembly] see fit to place teshuvah after binah [in the *Amidah*]? Because it is written, ‘and his heart shall understand and return and be healed’ (Yeshayah 6:10).” The Gemara then distinguishes the “healing” of forgiveness (which follows teshuvah directly) from bodily healing (which follows forgiveness): “that is not the healing of ailments but the healing of forgiveness.”

6 R' Tzadok — parallel (Tzidkas HaTzadik §159): “An individual who repents is forgiven, and the whole world with him (Yoma 86b) — and how is such forgiveness possible? Only that he arouses in their hearts too the stirrings of teshuvah; and not everyone who wishes to make himself such an ‘individual’ can do so, for it has not yet been — only *Mashiach ben David* will be so, for his soul must include all souls, since otherwise his own thoughts of teshuvah could not generate thoughts of teshuvah in one who has none.” This marks the outermost reach of the “greatness of teshuvah” that heads the work: from the very same Yoma 86 sugya, a single true penitent can draw a whole world after him — the summit toward which the seven rungs ascend.

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Siman 1

סִימָן א

Great is teshuvah, for it brings healing to the world

גְּדוּלָה תְּשׁוּבָה שְׁמַבִּיאה רְפוּאָה לְעוֹלָם.

“Great is teshuvah, for it brings healing to the world” (the first of the seven — corresponding to Chesed).

סעיף א — Se’if 1

The theme: The “healing” of this first rung is the healing of *forgiveness*, not bodily healing — a rectification going forward only. The moment a person’s heart stirs to return he is already called a complete tzaddik, before he has performed any labor upon the past. But a trace remains, as with a healed *baal mum*, or a convert whose earlier state is not wholly uprooted.

“That it brings healing to the world” — “שְׁמִיָּא רְפוּאָה לְעוֹלָם”, וְנִרְאָה לִי דְהֵינּוּ רְפוּאָה דְסְלִיחָה כְּלִישְׁנִיה דְקָרָא “אֲרַפָּא מְשׁוּבָתָם” [א] — **“That it brings healing to the world” — and it appears to me that this means the healing of *forgiveness*, in the language of the verse “I will heal their backsliding” (Hoshea 14:5)^{7, 8}, דְמַבְאָר דְקָאִי אֲמִשְׁוּבָה, וְדָלָא כְמַהֲרָשׁ”א בְחִדּוּשֵׁי אֲגֻדוֹת — which clearly refers to *backsliding* [sin], and not as the**

7 **Hoshea 14:5**: the climactic verse of the prophet’s call to teshuvah (ch. 14, “*Shuvah Yisrael*,” read as the haftarah of Shabbos Shuvah): “אֲרַפָּא מְשׁוּבָתָם, אֲהֲבֶם נְדָבָה, כִּי שָׁב אַפִּי מִמֶּנּוּ” — “I will heal their backsliding, I will love them freely, for My anger has turned away from him.” **Rashi** (from Tanchuma, Ekev): “once they say [the words of teshuvah] before Me, I will heal their backsliding [*meshuvah*] and love them with a generous spirit — though they are not worthy of the love, I will freely bestow it — for My anger has turned from them.” R’ Tzadok adduces this as the source that the “healing” of which the Gemara speaks (Yoma 86a, “great is teshuvah, for it brings healing”) is the healing of *forgiveness*: “*meshuvah*” means backsliding [sin], and it is precisely this that is “healed.” Chassidic parallels — the verse itself becomes a map of the first movement of teshuvah. Mei HaShiloach, Volume II, Prophets, Hoshea 14:1, reads the whole passage beginning “Ashur lo yoshienu” as Israel’s surrender of every claim to spiritual self-sufficiency. Good deeds, *zerizus*, *yirah*, and even fiery *ahavah* are not things in which a person can finally boast; the decisive point is the “kol demamah dakah,” the quiet Divine seal in the heart that the present movement truly accords with Hashem’s will. The Divine response is then precisely, “אֲרַפָּא מְשׁוּבָתָם, אֲהֲבֶם נְדָבָה כִּי שָׁב אַפִּי מִמֶּנּוּ” — “I will heal their backsliding... for My anger has turned from him,” which the Mei HaShiloach explains as the removal of Divine anger from Israel. This fits R’ Tzadok’s insistence that the first refuah is the refuah of selichah: before the past has been transformed, the relationship has already been reopened and the anger has turned away. Sefas Emes, Rosh HaShanah 25:4, develops the next words, “אֲהֲבֶם נְדָבָה.” There is an *ahavah* dependent upon conduct, which can be obscured when conduct fails, and there is the essential love of Israel because “*chelek Hashem amo*,” an *ahavah she-einah teluyah badavar*. Sin can conceal the soul’s revelation, but teshuvah reawakens it; hence “אֲרַפָּא מְשׁוּבָתָם” is followed by “אֲהֲבֶם נְדָבָה.” In the language of the Sefas Emes, the healing is not merely the cancellation of a punishment but the re-emergence of the neshama-level bond that the *aveirah* had hidden. This supplies a Chassidic basis for R’ Tzadok’s distinction between a wound that has been healed and the deeper root that was never destroyed. Tanya, Likkutei Amarim ch. 39 (39:19 in Sefaria’s segmentation), explicitly invokes the same *ma’amar*, “teshuvah brings healing to the world,” in a strikingly concrete way: Torah learned with an ulterior motive can be held temporarily in exile within *kelipas nogah*, “עד אשר יעשה תשובה שמביאה רפואה,” — until he does teshuvah, which brings healing to the world; when he returns to Hashem, his Torah returns with him. The “world” healed by teshuvah thus includes the person’s own earlier Torah and *avodah*: acts that were spiritually displaced are drawn back with the returning person. This is already a bridge from the first rung — healing from now on — toward the later rungs in which the past itself is recovered.

8 **Yoma 86a**: “R’ Chama b’Rabbi Chanina said: Great is teshuvah, for it brings healing to the world, as it says, ‘I will heal their backsliding, I will love them freely’ (Hoshea 14:5).” He further contrasts “Return, backsliding children” (implying they were always wayward — teshuvah from love, which makes the very origin as innocent) with “I will heal your backslidings” (implying, as Rashi explains, one healed like a cured *baal mum* of whom “a trace of his name remains” — teshuvah from fear).

Maharsha [held] in Chiddushei Aggados.⁹ והא דלא מ'יתי "ושב ורפא לו", דשם כתיב "לו" לשון יחיד, — **And the reason [the Gemara] does not adduce "and he shall return and be healed" (Yeshayah 6:10) is that there it is written "to him" in the singular; and thus [R' Chama] derives "to the world" from the fact that [the verse in Hoshea] opens in the plural and closes in the singular, as the Rif derives in Ein Yaakov.** ובגססות גמרא שקפנינו איתא "רפואות" לשון רבים, ואם הוא נסחא דווקנית יש לומר דתרתיה **And in our text of the Gemara it reads "healings [refu'os]" in the plural; if that is the precise text, one may say it states two — the healing of the soul and the healing of the body — for the one depends on the other,** כמו שנגאמר, דהא כהא תליא — **as it says, "Who forgives all your iniquity, Who heals all your diseases" (Tehillim 103:3)**¹⁰, and as is brought in Megillah there [17b].

דכל חללי הגוף של בני ישראל אינם במקרה כלל, רק מקבילים ממש לחללי הנפש, כמפרש בתורה כמה פעמים; **For all the bodily ailments of the Children of Israel are in no way happenstance, but correspond exactly to the ailments of the soul, as the Torah states many times; and the moment the soul is healed, the body too is healed.**¹¹ ומה שכתב מהרש"א — **ומה שכתב מהרש"א** — ליתא, דמפרש במגילה שם דרפואה דסליחה הוא תיקף אחר תשובה, ורפואה דתמלואים דעדיין לא נסלח — **And what the Maharsha wrote — that [at this stage] he has not yet been forgiven — is not so; for it is explicit in Megillah there that the "healing of forgiveness" comes immediately after teshuvah, while the "healing of ailments" comes after the forgiveness, not before it at all.**

והוא מדרגה הראשונה דתשובה — לרפואה מכאן ואילך על כל פנים; וזה בא מיד, ד"לכו ובינו ושב" — על ידי הרהור תשובה בלבד נקרא תיקף "צדיק גמור", כמו שאמרו בקדושין [מט:], אף דלא עשה עדיין כל תיקוניו — **And this is the first rung of teshuvah — healing from here on, at least; and it comes at once, for "his heart understands and returns" — through the mere thought of teshuvah in his heart he is immediately called a "complete tzaddik," as they said in Kiddushin [49b], even**

9 Maharsha, Chiddushei Aggados, Yoma 86a: questions why the Gemara did not prove that teshuvah brings healing "to the world" from "and he shall return and be healed to him" (Yeshayah 6:10), and suggests the verse speaks of literal healing, implying the sinner is not yet forgiven. R' Tzadok rejects this: the Gemara in Megillah makes explicit that the "healing" here is forgiveness itself, which comes immediately upon teshuvah — the sinner is at once forgiven.

10 Tehillim 103:3: "Who forgives all your iniquity, who heals all your diseases" — from David's psalm blessing Hashem for His benefactions to the soul. The two clauses run parallel — forgiveness of sin and healing of affliction — and the Gemara (**Megillah 17b**) derives from their order that the "healing" follows upon the "forgiveness": first the iniquity is pardoned, then the ailments are healed. R' Tzadok draws on this to explain the plural "*refu'os* [healings]" in the Gemara's text as two — the healing of the *soul* (forgiveness) and the healing of the *body* — "for the one depends on the other," the bodily ailments of Israel corresponding exactly to the ailments of the soul.

11 R' Tzadok — parallel (Dover Tzedek, Eruvin §4): "As it says in the first chapter of Kiddushin (40a), that a *good thought* the Holy One joins to the deed — even if he [merely] thought [to do a mitzvah] and was prevented by circumstance, Scripture reckons it for him as though he did it; but an evil thought is not joined to the deed, for the transgression is only in the deed, and it is bounded, like this world, the world of action, whereas thought has no bound or limit at all." The se'if's point precisely: the mere *thought* of teshuvah makes one "a complete tzaddik" at once — for thought reaches beyond the bounded world of deed.

though he has not yet performed any of the labors of teshuvah.¹²¹³ רַק הוּא כְּבָעַל מוֹם שְׁמִתְרַפָּא — הֵינּוּ לְמִי שְׁזוֹכֵר הָרָאשׁוֹנוֹת, יָדַע שֶׁהָיָה בְּעַל מוֹם, רַק דִּנְתְּרַפָּא עֲתִידָהּ, וְהוּא כְּגַר שְׁמִתְגַּיֵּיר, שְׁמִקְצֵת שְׁמוֹ עָלָיו — הֵינּוּ לְמִי שֶׁהוּא כְּקוֹטֵן שְׁנוּלֵד מִכָּאן וּלְהֵבָא, מִכָּל מְקוֹם אֵין נִעְקֵר הַקּוֹדֵם לְגַמְרִי לְהִיּוֹת כְּאַזְרַח בִּישְׁרָאֵל — **only that he is like a *baal mum* [a blemished one] who has been healed, of whom “a trace of his name remains” — that is, one who recalls the earlier things knows he was a *baal mum*, only that he is now healed; and he is like a convert who converts, that although he is “a newborn” from here on, nonetheless the earlier [state] is not wholly uprooted to make him like a native-born Israelite.**¹⁴

12 Kiddushin 49b: “[If a man betroths a woman] ‘on condition that I am a righteous man’ — even a completely wicked man — she is betrothed, for perhaps he had a thought of teshuvah in his mind.” R’ Tzadok adduces this as proof that a mere *thought* of teshuvah instantly renders one a “complete tzaddik,” even before any of the labors of rectification. Tanya and Izhbitz on the instantaneous halachic force of hirhur teshuvah. Tanya, Iggeres HaTeshuvah ch. 1 (1:7 in Sefaria’s segmentation), defines the Torah’s core mitzvah of teshuvah as “עֲזִיבַת הַחַטָּא בַּלֵּב” — abandoning the sin — meaning that one “יִגְמֹר בְּלֵב שְׁלֵם לֵב לְבַל שׁוּב עוֹד לְכַסְלָהּ” — resolves wholeheartedly in his heart not to return to rebellion against His kingship. That formulation is especially apt here: Kiddushin 49b does not require that the man’s biography already be visibly rewritten; the relevant question is whether, at that moment, the heart has truly turned. R’ Tzadok’s “complete tzaddik immediately” therefore accords with the Alter Rebbe’s definition of the essential act of teshuvah as a present, inward resolution, while the further avodos of remorse, confession, fasting, and rectification address other dimensions of kapparah and purification. Mei HaShiloach, Volume II, Talmud, Berachos 4a:2, uses this very Kiddushin passage to describe the radical openness of human bechirah from one moment to the next. A person has, as it were, two open doors: “בְּרִגְעָא אֶחָד יָכוֹל לְהַשְׁתַּנּוֹת וּלְהַטִּיב דְּרָכָיו” — in a single moment he can change and improve his ways — and there is likewise an opening in the opposite direction. The Izhbitzer cites both halves of Kiddushin: “al menas she’ani tzaddik,” perhaps he had a thought of teshuvah; and “al menas she’ani rasha,” perhaps a dark thought entered him. The point is not to minimize deeds but to insist that the living point of choice is never frozen by yesterday’s identity. This sharpens R’ Tzadok’s first rung of refuah: the past may still bear a scar, but the person’s present spiritual status can turn immediately because the inner point of bechirah is alive now.

13 R’ Tzadok — parallel (Tzidkas HaTzadik §145): “for the good, a good thought the Holy One joins to the deed” (Kiddushin 40a) — since “the soul You gave me is pure,” a good intent is reckoned as an act; “and in teshuvah, which takes all the [sinful] thoughts and returns them to their root, the deeds automatically remain a *dead body* without vitality.” This illuminates why a mere *thought* of teshuvah already makes one a “complete tzaddik”: for the good, thought itself counts as deed, and teshuvah’s thought withdraws the vitality the sins had drawn — leaving them lifeless — even before the labors of rectifying the past.

14 R’ Tzadok — parallel (Tzidkas HaTzadik §12): teshuvah has two aspects — the future and the rectification of the past — and correspondingly two “healings.” “It is established that atonement does not hold [teshuvah] back: for teshuvah, even if he [only] contemplated in his heart, *he is a complete tzaddik*” — yet this suffices only “for *terumah*, [that which is] lifted from the fully profane, to be at least within the class of a tzaddik; but for *kodshim* — one who wishes to sanctify himself and to be *holy* — he must also heal the past.” R’ Tzadok there anchors this in the Rambam’s “change of name” (one no longer stands in the very time and state of his defilement) and in “were the Holy One not to help him [he could not prevail].” This illuminates the se’if’s first rung: a stir of teshuvah instantly yields the “tzaddik” of forgiveness-going-forward, while the healed *baal mum*, of whom “a trace of his name remains,” still awaits the further healing of the past.

8

ועל כן הזהירה תורה על אונאת הגר כמה פעמים, שלא יאמר "פה שאכל גבילות" כו', כמו שאמרו בבבא
And therefore the Torah warned against *wronging the convert* many times — — [נח:]
that one not say to him, "a mouth that ate carcasses [now comes to learn Torah]," as they said
 ומהוצרך להזהיר משמע דהוא דבר שניתן ליאמר, דגש בו משום אונאה; דמה
in Bava Metzia [58b].
And from the very need to warn, it is implied that — שאינו קלל לא איכפת לאדם אם יאמרו עליו —
this is a thing that *can* be said — that there is in it [substance for] "*wronging*"; for that which
just as it did not trouble Yaakov that — כיון דאין לו שום שייכות עוד לזה —
is not [true] at all does not trouble a person if it is said of him,
just as it did not trouble Yaakov that — ולאברהם שיצא מטרח, כיון דאין לו שום שייכות עוד לזה —
he had a brother Esav, nor Avraham that he issued from Terach, since he has no connection to
it any longer. ומפני מה הזהירה תורה על הגרים — שטוחן רע, רצה לומר שרשן
 ויסודן באמת רע, על כן צריך הזהרה על אונאתו, שיש בו אונאת דברים גדולה, דעיקרה הוא באשר אומר דבר
And they said in Bava Metzia [59b], "Why did the Torah warn about converts — —
because their *inclination* is evil," meaning their root and foundation are in truth [susceptible
 to] evil; therefore a warning against wronging him is needed, for there is in it a *great verbal*
wronging — its essence being precisely when one speaks a true thing about him,²¹ אן פועל בו

especially relevant to R' Tzadok's language of changing the former state. After the Akeidah, milah, and the ten nisyonos, Avraham was "גשטנה מהיפך להיפך, כענין גר שנתגייר" — changed from one opposite to the other, like a convert who must overturn an ingrained former way. Rebirth is therefore not only a juridical severance from the old past but the revelation of a newly ordered personality. At the same time, these sources help preserve R' Tzadok's distinction here. A ger can truly become a new person from this point onward, yet R' Tzadok asks a different, more radical question: can the earlier reality itself become good? Resisei Layla §41 answers that for the ger the former world can be forgotten and submerged, but not transformed into a good Jewish root that was already present there. Shem MiShmuel, Shabbos Shuvah 3:12, compares the highest teshuvah to total immersion: when all the powers of the soul are swallowed into teshuvah one becomes "כקטן שנוול"; this is precisely why the analogy is so powerful for R' Tzadok — ordinary rebirth means a new beginning, whereas the higher Jewish power of teshuvah can ultimately go beyond beginning anew and recast the past itself.

19 Bava Metzia 58b: the Mishnah (*Bava Metzia* 4:10) teaches — "Just as there is *ona'ah* [wronging] in buying and selling, so is there *ona'ah* in words. If one is a *baal teshuvah*, one may not say to him, 'Remember your earlier deeds'; and if he is the child of converts, one may not say to him, 'Remember the deeds of your ancestors' — as it is said, 'And a convert you shall not wrong, nor oppress him' (Shemos 22:20)." The Gemara adds: "If he was a convert who came to study Torah, one may not say to him, 'Shall a mouth that ate carcasses and *tereifos*, abominations and creeping things, come to study the Torah that was uttered from the mouth of the Almighty?'" This is the source R' Tzadok cites for the Torah's repeated warning against *ona'as ha-ger*.

20 R' Tzadok — parallel (Tzidkas HaTzadik §77): "even a very great person, if there is a blemish in his family, one should not attach oneself to him — for [even] if [it is tolerated] on account of his own greatness, it will yet harm his offspring," as in "even were he like Yehoshua bin Nun, I would not give him [my daughter]" (*Yevamos* 45a); "yet from the side of the *crown of Torah* one need not be concerned about lineage, for the crown of Torah is set out for all... and the foundation of the Oral Torah is R' Akiva, who was of a family of converts." This illumines the se'if from the other side: the convert's root-blemish is real and reaches his seed, yet the crown of Torah wholly transcends it — a "mouth that ate carcasses" can become the very wellspring of the Oral Torah.

21 Bava Metzia 59b: "It is taught — R' Eliezer the Great says: For what reason did the Torah warn in thirty-six places, and some say in forty-six places, concerning the convert? Because his inclination is evil (*mipnei she-soro ra*)" [R' Tzadok's text reads *she-tochen ra*]. The Gemara continues (R' Nassan): "'And a convert you shall not wrong, nor oppress him, for you were strangers in the land of Egypt' — a blemish that is in you, do not

— הרבה, עד שיכול לפעול בו על ידי זה שינוי בעצמותו, על ידי שמזכיר החסרון שהוא באמת כן בעצם — **for then it works upon him greatly, to the point that it can effect in him a change in his very essence, through mentioning the deficiency that is in truth so in essence.**

סעיף 3 — Se'if 3

The theme: The same caution extends to the *baal teshuvah*: “do not say to him, remember your former deeds.” At teshuvah’s beginning the past is not yet visibly rectified, so the reminder still stings. David, who raised up the yoke of teshuvah, was pained by it — and that his sin had been rectified retroactively was not made known in his own lifetime.

— וחו"ל הוסיפו במלשנה [שם נח:] גם לבעל תשובה “[לא יאמר] זכר מעשיך [הראשונים]” [ג] **And the Sages added in the Mishnah [Bava Metzia 58b] [this warning] also regarding a *baal teshuvah*: “[one may not say to him,] remember your former deeds,”**²² וסוף אף דחטאי ישראל אינם בעצם, וסוף — **even though the sins of Israel are not of their essence, and the end of teshuvah is to rectify the past as well, so as to be as if he had never sinned at all.**²³ ועל כן אין בנה האזהרה בתורה, שהיא מצד האמת הנמור — לא שייד אונאת דברים זו כלל; **And therefore this warning is not in the Torah [itself] — for from the side of the utter truth this “verbal wronging” does not apply at all; only the Sages added it, since even in a *baal teshuvah*, at the beginning of the rung of teshuvah, the rectification of the past is not yet revealed.**²⁴²⁵

ascribe to your fellow (*mum she-becha al tomar la-chavercha*.)” This is precisely R’ Tzadok’s point here: verbal wronging “works upon” a person only because it names a real deficiency in his root.

22 Bava Metzia 58b: the Mishnah (Bava Metzia 4:10), having taught that “just as there is *ona’ah* [wronging] in buying and selling, so is there *ona’ah* in words,” rules: “if one is a *baal teshuvah*, one may not say to him, ‘remember your former deeds.’” R’ Tzadok notes that this clause — unlike the warning against wronging the convert — is not the Torah’s own prohibition (for from the side of absolute truth a Jew’s sin is not of his essence, and no true “wronging” applies); the Sages *added* it, because at the beginning of teshuvah the rectification of the past is not yet manifest. The same daf continues (**Bava Metzia 58b–59a**): “whoever whitens the face of his fellow in public is as though he sheds blood” — Rav Nachman bar Yitzchak observing, “we see that the red departs [*azil sumka*] and pallor comes.” This is R’ Tzadok’s source for reading the “whitening of the face” as the *departing of the red*, i.e. of the blood — “the blood is the soul,” the animal soul that is the seat of sin — so that at the mention of an as-yet-unrectified sin the penitent’s blood is “swallowed within him.”

23 R’ Tzadok — parallel (Tzidkas HaTzadik §158): “Through *mesirus nefesh* unto death in one’s very thought, in complete truth — that he consents in his heart that if it be God’s will and better for him to die, he desires it willingly — he is saved from the decree of death... for his thought and his acceptance upon himself is *reckoned as the deed itself*, and it is thereafter as though he had come in a second *gilgul* to this world, knowing what he had spoiled in the first, and able to *rectify it*; and there is no sin [that cannot thus be mended].” This is the very mechanism of §1-3’s higher rung — “the root of Israel that can change even the past”: the wholehearted giving-over of the *nefesh* (the “blood” that is the *nefesh*) sets a man, as it were, in a new life over against his old, from which he can reach back and heal what was.

24 Cf. R’ Tzadok’s fuller treatment of David as “the one who raised up the yoke of teshuvah” in Takanas HaShavin 11 and Pri Tzaddik (Pinchas §15; Vayeilech / Shabbos Shuvah §21): David “was not fit for that deed” and acted only “to teach teshuvah,” and Mashiach will be *the individual* whose teshuvah draws forgiveness upon the whole world.

25 R’ Tzadok — parallel (Tzidkas HaTzadik §164): “In the reckoning of people the *baal teshuvah* is not [seen] as a complete tzaddik... because teshuvah is called ‘*alma de-iskasya*’ [the concealed world], and its

וְדוֹד הַמֶּלֶךְ ע"ה נִשְׁהִיָּה "הַגִּבֹּר נִשְׁהִיָּה עַלֵּה נֶשְׁלֵה" כְּמוֹ שְׁאָמְרוּ בְּעִבּוּדָה יָרָה [ה.], אָמְרוּ בְּבָבָא מְצִיעָא
 [נט.] שֶׁהָיוּ מְלַבֵּינִים פָּנָיו עַל יְדֵי הַזְכָּרָת הַחֲטָא עַד שֶׁאִם הָיוּ קוֹרְעִים בְּשָׂרוֹ כִּי — **And David HaMelech,**
who was “the man who raised up the yoke of teshuvah,” as they said in Avodah Zarah [5a], of
whom they said in Bava Metzia [59a] that they would “whiten his face” through mentioning
the sin, to the point that “were they to tear his flesh [no blood would flow],” etc.²⁶²⁷ דְּהִלְבֵּנָת פָּנִים

preciousness and beauty are not revealed to people” — even though the Sages taught, “in the place where baalei teshuvah stand [the wholly righteous cannot stand]” (Berachos 34b). He likens it to Leah, who “was hated” and wept — the hidden secret of teshuvah — against Rachel of “revealed beauty”; yet the essential offspring are from Leah, “for the essence of birth, the renewal of Torah and of souls by God’s will, is all through the rung of teshuvah.” This illuminates why David’s face was whitened at the mention of his sin, and why the higher rung — full rectification of the past, with no shame at all — “was not yet revealed in his lifetime”: teshuvah’s beauty belongs to the *concealed* world. Izhbitz-Radzin parallel to Leah as alma d’iskasya. Beis Yaakov on Torah, Vayetzei 63:1, explicitly describes the zivug of Yaakov and Leah as “עלמא דאתכסיא,” above ordinary human grasp. Rachel’s beauty and the stature of her children are visible on the surface; Leah and her children repeatedly require later birur. Yehudah and Tamar, Reuven and Bilhah, and other episodes can look compromised at the moment of occurrence while their inner place in the Divine plan emerges only later. That is exactly the phenomenology R’ Tzadok assigns to teshuvah: its “yofi” is concealed because the present observer still sees the broken history, whereas the deeper birur by which that history becomes the vehicle of a higher birth is not yet visible. Beis Yaakov, Vayetzei 66:2, develops the same point through Leah’s naming of Yehudah. On the surface she appears to have received Yehudah without the same visible struggle as the earlier children, yet “אין הקב”ה נותן בחנם רק על ידי יגיעה”; her hidden labor in the first three births is gathered into the fourth. Therefore she says “הפעם אודה את ה’,” and the Midrash’s “Leah grasped hoda’ah, and her children opened with hoda’ah” becomes a principle: what appeared externally unearned or even unattractive is later disclosed as the fruit of hidden avodah. R’ Tzadok’s equation of Leah with teshuvah is thus thoroughly Ishbitzian: the baal teshuvah belongs to a world in which the truth of a life cannot be read from its first visible form. This also explains the David connection. David descends from Leah through Yehudah, and his own teshuvah remains an “alma d’iskasya” in his lifetime: forgiven, yet publicly shamed; inwardly rooted in the future Malchus, yet without the visible vindication that comes only through Shlomo. The concealed-world pattern of Leah becomes the historical pattern of Davidic teshuvah.

26 Avodah Zarah 5a: “The utterance of David son of Yishai, and the utterance of the man raised up on high [hukam al]’ (Shmuel II 23:1) — the man who raised up the yoke [ulah] of teshuvah.” **Bava Metzia 59a:** David said before the Holy One, “Master of the Universe, it is revealed before You that if they were to tear my flesh my blood would not flow to the ground [from shame], for even when they are engaged in [the laws of] leprosy marks and tents they say to me: David, one who comes upon a married woman — his death is by what? And I say to them: his death is by strangulation, yet he has a share in the World to Come; but one who publicly shames his fellow has no share in the World to Come.”

27 Shmuel II 12:13: After the affair of Bas-Sheva and Uriah (Shmuel II ch. 11), the prophet Nathan came to David, told him the parable of the poor man’s ewe lamb, and declared, “You are the man!” (12:7), decreeing that “the sword shall never depart from your house” (12:10). David answered: “וַיֹּאמֶר דָּוִד אֶל־נָתָן: חֲטָאתִי לָהּ.” — “David said to Nathan: ‘I have sinned against Hashem.’” And Nathan said to David: “Hashem, too, has removed your sin; you shall not die” (Shmuel II 12:13). **Radak** explains that “also (*gam*)” comes to include David’s confession — “as you confess, so too He has accepted your teshuvah”; and “you shall not die” means “not the death of the wicked, whose soul descends to Gehinnom — though you will still be punished in this world,” namely the death of the child, Avshalom’s rebellion, and “the sword shall not depart from your house.” It is upon this instantaneous exchange — a single word of confession met at once with “Hashem has removed your sin” — that Chazal call David “the man who raised up the yoke of

הוא על ידי דאָזיגן סופמקא, וְשֶׁהוּא הַדָּם שֶׁמִּחְמַתוֹ הַחַטָּא; כִּי הַדָּם הוּא הַנֶּפֶשׁ כַּמְפָּרֶשׁ בְּקֶרֶא וְקֹאֵי אֲבֵהֶמָּה — כִּי
For the — הִיא נֶפֶשׁ הַבְּהֵמִית שֶׁבָּאֶדָם שֶׁמִּמֶּנָּה הַחַטָּא, וְעָלֶיהָ הוּא פִּשְׁטִיָּה דְקֶרֶא “נֶפֶשׁ כִּי הַחַטָּא”
“whitening of the face” occurs through the departing of the red — that is, the blood, from
which the sin comes; for “the blood is the soul,” as the verse states explicitly, and it refers to
the animal [dimension] — for it is the animal soul within man, from which sin issues, and it is
upon this soul that the plain sense of the verse “a soul that sins” [speaks]. וְכֵן אֵימָא בְּבִבָּא בְתָרָא
 [נח:] “בְּרִישׁ כָּל מַרְעִין אֲנָא דָם”, וְעַל כֵּן בְּהִזְכָּרַת הַחַטָּא כְּשֶׁעֲדִיין לֹא נִתְקַן הַקּוֹדֶם נִבְלַע דְמוּ בְתוֹכוֹ
And so it is [stated] in Bava Basra [58b], “at the head of all illnesses am I, blood,” and therefore, at the
mention of the sin — when the past is not yet rectified — his blood is “swallowed” within
him.²⁸ וְדוּד הַמֶּלֶךְ ע"ה הוּא הַתְחַלְת מַדְרָגוֹת הַתְּשׁוּבָה, וְשֶׁהוּא הַרְפוּאָה לְהֵבָא, דְּעַל זֶה נִתְבַּשֵּׁר “גַּם ה' הַעֲבִיר
 חַטָּאתְךָ לֹא תָמוּת” — **And David HaMelech is the beginning of the rungs of teshuvah, which is**
the healing going forward, for regarding this he was assured, “the Lord has also removed your
sin, you shall not die” (Shmuel II 12:13).²⁹ — אֲבָל לְהַיּוֹת נִתְקַן לְשַׁעֲבֵר, שְׁלֹא יִהְיֶה לוֹ בּוֹשָׁה עוֹד בְּזֶה כִּלְל —
 דְּבָר זֶה לֹא יָדְעוּ עֲדִיין בְּחַיּוֹ, כִּמּוֹ שֶׁאֲמָרוּ בְּשִׁבְתָּ [ל.] “בְּחַיִּיר אֵינִי מוֹדִיעַ” כּו', כִּי אַז לֹא נִתְגַּלָּה עֲדִיין מַדְרָגָה זוֹ שֶׁל
 הַתְּשׁוּבָה — **But that the past be rectified — so that he have no shame in it at all any longer —**

teshuvah” (Avodah Zarah 5a); cf. Shabbos 56a, “whoever says David sinned is merely mistaken,” and Shabbos 30a, that the full manifestation of his atonement was withheld in his lifetime. Izhbitz on David's purification. Mei HaShiloach, Volume II, Writings, Tehillim 51:1, comments on David's plea “תַּחֲטָאֲנִי בְּאֻזֹּב וְאִטְהַר” He distinguishes a supernal purification in which Hashem illuminates the depth of the heart so that the person recognizes that he was bound to Him even in the hour of sin, from the more constricted purification of the ezov, given to the most distant forms of tumah. The latter requires extreme self-contraction, recognition of lowliness, and sweeping away every trace of ga'avah. David, the Mei HaShiloach says, longed so intensely for taharah that he was prepared for either path: like a man covered in filth who says to his friend, cleanse me with whatever broom you choose, only cleanse and purify me. “תַּחֲטָאֲנִי בְּאֻזֹּב” therefore expresses not self-justification but a willingness to undergo the deepest birur. That teaching is important for reading the Izhbitz-Radzin doctrine of yedi'ah and bechirah in connection with David. The higher disclosure — that even during the sin the deepest neshama had never ceased to be attached to Hashem — is a *result* of purification, not a permission granted beforehand to follow desire. Before the birur, David's avodah is confession, brokenness, and readiness for correction. Only after that can there be a revelation of a level on which the root-attachment was never severed. Shem MiShmuel repeatedly cites the Zohar on “גַּם ה' הַעֲבִיר חַטָּאתְךָ לֹא תָמוּת” as referring to the removal of the destructive accuser generated by sin. In Nitzavim 2:15 and Sukkos 3:2-3, he explains that the sin itself creates a prosecuting force that closes the heart; through true vidui and teshuvah that force is “passed away” so the person can again turn toward Hashem. This fits R' Tzadok's exact wording of the first rung. “Hashem has removed your sin; you shall not die” is genuine and immediate healing — the death-bearing obstruction is removed — even though the later punishments in David's life show that the complete revelation of retroactive tikkun has not yet arrived.

28 Bava Basra 58b: “[Shmuel said:] at the head of all illnesses am I — blood”; Rashi: “all of a person's ailments come on account of the blood.” R' Tzadok links the “blood” (the seat of the animal soul and of sin) to the “whitening of the face” (the draining of red) that shame produces when an unrectified sin is recalled.

29 R' Tzadok — parallel (Resisei Layla §28): “This is the rung of David, who ‘raised up the yoke of teshuvah’ — for although he went where he went and sank where he sank, he can return to his root and his place in holiness, at the highest rung; as is known to the seers of the Merkavah, that every light appears like the flash of lightning — to the place from which they go, from there they return, in the sense of ‘from there He will take you’ (Devarim 30:4): specifically ‘from there,’ from the very lowest, he draws wholly close to Hashem.” This is the se'if's David — “the beginning of the rungs of teshuvah,” the healing that reaches even the one sunk lowest.

this was not yet known in his lifetime, as they said in Shabbos [30a], “in your lifetime I will not make [it] known,” etc.; for then this [higher] rung of teshuvah had not yet been revealed.³⁰

ד עיף — Se’if 4

The theme: David’s root runs back to Avraham, who began as “first of the converts” and only afterward revealed himself as father of the nation. Because Yitzchak was born to him, and the branch is contained in the root, the whole of Knesses Yisrael was folded into him. This is “the root of Israel” — a root cleaving to God with no dross at all, so that sins are incidental to it, thorns standing around a rose.

[ד] — **And the foundation [yesod] of Avraham Avinu’s rung is this: that he was “first of the converts,” as they said in Chagigah [3a].**³¹ ר' אהרן כהן מלשון יצחק ואיתן האזרחי להיות כאזרח — **only afterward, once Yitzchak was born and was “en clothed” within him, did he merit the name “Eisan HaEzrachi” — to be like a native-born in Israel — for Hashem assured him, “yours is the dew of your youth” (Tehillim 110:3)**³², כמו — **אמר בבראשית רבה [פ' לט] “תאמר ניש בנדי עון” כו', ודרשו “מרתמו של עולם”**

30 Shabbos 30a: David asked for a sign that his sin was forgiven; God replied, “In your lifetime I will not make it known; in the lifetime of your son Shlomo I will make it known.” When Shlomo brought the Ark into the Holy of Holies and the gates would not open, he was answered only when he invoked “remember the kindnesses of David Your servant” — “at that moment the faces of all David’s enemies turned black, and all knew that God had forgiven him.” R’ Tzadok: the *retroactive* rectification (removing all shame) was not manifest in David’s own lifetime, for that higher rung had not yet been revealed.

31 Chagigah 3a (and Bereishis Rabbah): Avraham is called “the father of converts” — the first to bring others “under the wings of the Shechinah.” R’ Tzadok: Avraham’s own starting-point was that of a *ger*, and only after fathering Yitzchak did he reveal his deeper root as native-born father of Israel. Avraham’s transition from *ger* to root-father in Chassidus. Beis Yaakov, Chayei Sarah 24:1, portrays Avraham after milah, Akeidah, and the ten nisyonos as a person transformed “מהיפך להיפך” in the manner of a *ger*. Yet the very same transformation reveals, rather than manufactures, the depth for which he was created. This is close to R’ Tzadok’s paradox: Avraham begins historically as the first *ger*, but after Yitzchak is included in him the earlier stage itself can be read from the standpoint of his native root as father of Israel. Kedushas Levi, Lech Lecha §37, similarly refuses to define Avraham by Terach. Using “ger shenisgayer ke-katan shenolad,” he argues that Avraham’s true *av* is the Divine middah and mission from which he is spiritually hewn — the revelation of Hashem’s Name through the future Jewish people. Thus the *ger*-principle becomes not simply erasure of ancestry but discovery of a deeper ancestry. R’ Tzadok pushes this one step farther: once Yitzchak and Yaakov are understood as already latent in Avraham, the branch discloses what was hidden in the root, and the past can be reread accordingly.

32 Tehillim 110:3: “עמך נִבְּחָת בְּיוֹם חֵילָךְ, בְּהַדְרֵי קֹדֶשׁ מִרְחֹם מְשַׁחֵר, לֵךְ טַל יִלְדוּתֶיךָ” — a verse whose plain meaning is famously difficult. **Rashi** reads the psalm as addressed to Avraham: “your people will volunteer on the day of your host” — when Avraham mustered his men to pursue the four kings (Bereishis 14), Aner, Eshkol, and Mamre going out with him of their own accord; “in the beauty of holiness, from the womb” — in the merit of the holiness that was in him from his mother’s womb, for “he recognized his Creator at the age of three” (Nedarim 32a); and “yours is the dew of your youth [*lecha tal yaldusecha*]” — “your youth shall be reckoned to you: the ways of uprightness by which you conducted yourself in your youth will be to you as pleasant as this dew.” R’ Tzadok links this to the Midrash (**Bereishis Rabbah 39**) that Avraham feared, “shall I say that there is sin in my hand?” and was reassured that he is “the beloved of the world [*meruchamo shel olam*]”: Avraham was in truth holy from the womb, so that his *beginning* as a convert — the “youth” preceding the revealing of his root — is itself like dew, pure and pleasant, and no taint.

Bereishis Rabbah [39:8], “[Avraham feared:] shall I say that there is sin in my hand?” and they expounded “the beloved [or: the one shown mercy from creation] of the world.”³³ הָיָינוּ דְּבָאֲמָתָא גַּם אַבְרָהָם אָבִינוּ ע"ה הִזָּה קְדוֹשׁ מִרְחָם וּמִתְחַלֵּת בְּרִייתוֹ שֶׁל עוֹלָם, וְרַק תְּחִלָּתוֹ הִיָּתָה כְּגֵר; אָבֵל אַחֵר — **That is, that in truth Avraham Avinu, too, was holy from the womb and from the very beginning of the world’s creation; only his beginning was as a convert, but afterward he merited to reveal his root — that he is the father of the world and the root of the entire Israelite nation** שֶׁהוּא הַתְּחִלָּת יַחַס זֶה דְּשִׁרְשׁ יִשְׂרָאֵל, — **which is the beginning of this lineage of “the root of Israel,” which can change even the past.**³⁴

וְעַל כֵּן אָמְרוּ ו"ל [בר"ר סג, ב] דִּיעֲקֹב פָּדָה אֶת אַבְרָהָם [מִכְּבִשָּׁן הָאֵשׁ], רָצָה לוֹמַר שִׁרְשׁ יַעֲקֹב שֶׁהִיָּה כְּלוּל בּוֹ, כִּי — **And therefore the Sages said [Bereishis Rabbah 63:2] that “Yaakov redeemed Avraham [from the fiery furnace]” — meaning the root of Yaakov that was contained within him; for a thing cannot give what is not in it, and the branch is always contained in the root, and the children’s power is stored within the fathers.**³⁵ וְכִשְׁנִתְּסַף בּוֹ ה', הוּא ה' אֶחְרֹנָה דְּשֵׁם הַרוּמָתָא לְכַנְסָתָא יִשְׂרָאֵל, נִכְלָל בּוֹ כֹּל שִׁרְשׁ כְּנֻסָּתָא — **And when the *heh* was added to him [Avram → Avraham] — the final *heh* of the Divine Name, which alludes to Knesses Yisrael — there was included in him all the root of Knesses Yisrael of every generation.**³⁶ וְשִׁרְשׁ יִשְׂרָאֵל הוּא דְּשִׁרְשָׁם דְּבֹקֵם בְּהַש"ת וְאֵין נֶשֶׁם פְּסֻלָּתָא. כָּאֵסָא דְּקֹאֵי בִינֵי הַצִּי שֶׁהִמְשִׁילוּ כָּלֵל, כִּיעֲקֹב אָבִינוּ ע"ה שֶׁמִּשְׁתַּחֲוִי שְׁלִימָה; וְכֹל הַחֲטָאִים אֵינָם בְּעֶצֶם רַק בְּמִקְרָה, כָּאֵסָא דְּקֹאֵי בִינֵי הַצִּי שֶׁהִמְשִׁילוּ — **And “the root of Israel” is one whose root cleaves to Hashem with no dross at all — like Yaakov Avinu, “whose bed was whole”; and all the sins are not essential but incidental, “like a myrtle that stands among thorns,” the parable the Sages gave in Sanhedrin**

33 Bereishis Rabbah 39:8 (on Tehillim 110:3, “yours is the dew of your youth”): “Avraham feared and said: shall I say I have sin in my hand, that I served idols all these years? God said: ‘yours is the dew of your youth’ — just as dew evaporates, so your sins evaporate.” The Midrash reads *merechem mishachar* as “the one shown mercy from [the creation of] the world” — i.e. Avraham’s merit predates the world. R’ Tzadok: Avraham was in essence holy from the womb; the “convert” phase was only his beginning.

34 R’ Tzadok — parallel (Machshavos Charutz §11): “Avraham Avinu, who is called ‘first of the converts’ (Chagigah 3a) — it is brought that he ‘bound the twenty-two letters of the Torah on his tongue,’ that he merited at first only the letters of speech, until he fathered Yitzchak, and after the tenth trial, when [Yitzchak] was ‘incorporated’ [within him] — and this was on Rosh Hashanah, as they said (Rosh Hashanah 10a) that Sarah was remembered, that is, in conception, from which time he is called ‘father.’” This is the se’if’s Avraham: he *began* as a *ger*, and only once he fathered Yitzchak did he reveal his root as father of the nation.

35 Bereishis Rabbah 63:2: “Yaakov redeemed Avraham” — the merit/root of Yaakov (whose “bed was whole,” with no unfit offspring) was already contained within Avraham and “redeemed” him. R’ Tzadok’s principle: the branch is contained in the root, so the whole future nation was folded into Avraham once he fathered Yitzchak, all the more so when the *heh* of the Name (Knesses Yisrael) was joined to him (Avram → Avraham).

36 R’ Tzadok — parallel (Tzidkas HaTzadik §172): “Just as there is, in place, the *even shesiyah* [foundation stone] from which the world was founded — and it is the root of the whole world — so among souls there is one soul that includes the whole generation, which is the *parnas ha-dor* [leader of the generation]; and likewise one that includes all the generations; and so too in time there is a time that includes all the days, which is the day of Shabbos.” This illuminates Avraham’s rung in the se’if: as “father of the world and root of the entire Israelite nation,” he is the *even shesiyah* of Knesses Yisrael — the single root-soul in whom “all the root of Knesses Yisrael of every generation” is folded, so that “the branch is contained in the root” and even the past can be changed from within him.

The theme: Rectifying the past is the higher rung; the *beginning* of teshuvah is Avraham's — bringing healing to the world at least from now on. Rectification of the past belongs to Israel alone, whose root is truly good; the nations have only a forward-healing, and even that does not endure with them. This first rung, however, embraces the entire world.

ותהו תיקון הקודם, שִׁבְשֵׁב עֹן יִשְׂרָאֵל וְאִינְנוּ; אֲבָל הַתַּחֲלַת הַתְּשׁוּבָה הוּא דְרָגָא דְאַבְרָהָם אֲבִינוּ ע"ה מִצֵּד [הא] And this [uprooting of the past] is the rectification of what came before — “the sin of Israel shall be sought and there shall be none” (Yirmeyah 50:20)³⁹; but the *beginning* of teshuvah is the rung of Avraham Avinu from his own side, who was father to the whole world, to bring healing to the world at least from here on. דְּלִתְקַן הַקּוֹדֵם אִי אֶפְשָׁר בְּכָל הָעוֹלָם כְּלוּ, שֶׁהָיוּ בְּיָמָיו גּוֹיִם, וְלֹא נִתְּנָה תְּשׁוּבָה אֵלָּא. For to rectify the past is impossible for the entire world, since in his days there were gentiles, and teshuvah was given only to Israel — for the Torah was given and the laws of teshuvah were newly instituted [ע וְהָיָה דְרָאִיתִי כֵן לְהַרמ"ע בְּשִׁשְׁרָה מֵאַמְרוֹת, וְלֹהֲר"י אֲבָרְבָנְאֵל בְּנִחְלַת אֲבוֹת, וְעוֹד קְדָמוֹנִים; וְשׁוֹב מִצְאֵתִי מִפְּרֵשׁ בְּתַנְחומָא [פ' הָאֲזִינוּ] וְנִהְיֵינָא דְרָאִיתִי כֵן לְהַרמ"ע] — [and I recall having seen thus in the Ramma in *Asarah Ma'amaros*, and in R' Yitzchak Abarbanel in *Nachalas Avos*, and other early authorities; and I later found it explicit in Tanchuma (Ha'azinu): “one who does teshuvah, He shows him favor — one might think to all; therefore Scripture says ‘to you’ — and not to another nation”].⁴⁰⁴¹ וְלֹא יִשְׂרָאֵל שֶׁשָּׂדֵשׁ בְּאַמֶּת טוֹב, וְעַל כֵּן נִתְּנָה תּוֹרַת לֵהֵם; וְלֹא [given] to Israel, whose root is truly good, and

37 Sanhedrin 44a: On “Israel has sinned” (Yehoshua 7:11), R’ Abba bar Zavda said: “Even though he sinned, he is [still] Israel.” R’ Abba added the folk-adage: “a myrtle [*asa*] that stands among thorns [*chilfei*] — its name is myrtle and they call it myrtle.” R’ Tzadok: Israel’s sins are “thorns around the rose,” incidental and severable, never the essence of the root, which cleaves wholly to God.

38 R' Tzadok — parallel (Tzidkas HaTzadik §131): “The root of the souls of all Israel is from the Source of life... and this matter was first revealed in full clarity through Bilaam, whose entire passage concerns this virtue of Israel — that even should they pile sins one upon another, the love of the Holy One is *not severed from them by so much as a hair’s breadth*” (and Bilaam, who had no share in the World to Come, was its unwilling herald). This is the very point of “the root of Israel” in the se’if: the root “cleaves to Hashem with no dross at all,” so that the sins are but incidental thorns encircling the rose — they can be cut away and the rose “left wholly clean and whole, as it is in its own essence.”

39 Yirmeyah 50:20: “יִבְקֹשׁ אֶת עֶן יִשְׂרָאֵל וְאֵינֶנּוּ, וְאֵת חַטָּאת יְהוּדָה וְלֹא תִמְצָא יְנֶה, כִּי: — “In those days and at that time, says Hashem, the iniquity of Israel shall be sought and there shall be none, and the sins of Judah and none shall be found; for I will pardon those I leave as a remnant.” The verse falls within Yirmeyah’s prophecy of the downfall of Bavel and the return of Israel (ch. 50): at that future time Israel’s sin is not merely forgiven but “sought and not found” — uprooted entirely. This is R’ Tzadok’s emblem for the highest rung of teshuvah, the rectification of the past itself. **Radak** explains that the verse must speak of the Messianic future — “for I will pardon” — since sinners still remained throughout the Second Temple and this present exile; and “to the remnant I leave” likewise points to that time, as in “he who remains in Zion and is left in Jerusalem shall be called holy” (Yeshayah 4:3) and “the remnant of Israel shall do no wrong” (Tzefaniah 3:13).

therefore the Torah was given to them; and “He did not do so for any [other] nation,” for they have no connection in their root with the Torah.⁴² וְרַק רְפוּאָה לְהֵבֵא זֶה לֹשׁ גַּם בְּגוֹיִם, כְּמוֹ שֶׁכְּתוּב: בְּנִינְיָה כְּשֶׁשָּׁבוּ מִדֶּרֶךְם דִּנְתַּבְּטַל הַפּוֹדָעוֹת הַנִּגְזָר, דָּעַל כָּל פְּנִיִּים הַשְׁתָּא מִיָּהִת לֹא חֲטָאוּ, וְלַעוֹלָם עוֹן עֲצָמוּ אֵינוֹ נִמְחָק קָלָל גְּבִי'הוּ — And only “healing going forward” exists among the nations too, as it is written of Nineveh, that when they turned from their way the decreed punishment was annulled — for at any rate *now* they do not sin; but the sin itself is never erased with them at all.⁴³

40 Yerushalmi Makkos 2:6: “They asked Wisdom: what is the sinner’s punishment? It said, ‘evil pursues sinners’ (Mishlei 13:21). They asked Prophecy: ‘the soul that sins shall die’ (Yechezkel 18:4). They asked the Holy One: ‘let him do teshuvah and it will atone for him.’” — **Tanchuma, Ha’azinu:** “One who does teshuvah, He shows him favor — one might think for all [nations]; Scripture says ‘to you’ — and not to another nation.” R’ Tzadok marshals these (with the Ramma and Abarbanel) that the Torah’s *innovation* of teshuvah-that-rectifies-the-past was given to Israel alone; the nations have only “healing going forward” (as at Nineveh). Chassidic explanation of why teshuvah belongs uniquely to the root of Israel. Shem MiShmuel, Ki Seitzei 2:17, writes that the effectiveness of teshuvah for Israel is bound to their essential connection to Avraham, Yitzchak, and Yaakov. Jewish souls are “בעצם נפשות טהורות וטובות” — intrinsically pure and good — and aveiros are a contingent soiling. When a Jew returns, the inner point reconnects with the chain reaching the Avos and a new current of life can flow from the root. This is nearly the same metaphysical distinction R’ Tzadok draws here between sin that is incidental to a good shores and sin that belongs to an essence lacking that root. Tanya, Likkutei Amarim ch. 2 (2:1), supplies the Chabad formulation of the same root claim: “נפש השנית בישראל היא: חלק אליה ממעל ממש.” The Divine soul of Israel is not merely an ethically improved personality but a soul whose deepest origin is Godly. On this account teshuvah can be more than behavioral correction: return is literally return to the soul’s own source. R’ Tzadok’s language remains his own and should not be collapsed into Tanya’s system, but the comparison clarifies why a Jewish past can ultimately be healed from within: the deepest subject of that past was never identical with the sin.

41 R’ Tzadok — parallel (Resisei Layla §54): “Whereas the nations of the world — even should they repent — ‘teshuvah was given only to Israel’ (Midrash Tanchuma Ha’azinu 4); but for them there is no atonement at all, *for by them the sin is in its very essence [be-etzem].*” This is the ground of §1-5’s ruling that among the nations “it is not an enduring healing, and in the end the wound is destined to reopen”: the Torah’s teshuvah was legislated for Israel alone — “whose root is truly good” — so their sins are but incidental thorns, whereas for the nations the sin cleaves to the essence itself, and even their “forward-healing” cannot hold. R’ Tzadok there rests the point, exactly as the se’if does, on the same Tanchuma: “*to you* — and not to another nation.”

42 R’ Tzadok — parallel (Yisrael Kedoshim §5): Amalek, “the first of the nations,” aims his whole grievance at the very distinction between Israel and the nations — “he wants, God forbid, that the house of Israel be like all the nations.” But “Amalek’s whole grasp is only upon the outward appearance [*le-mar’is ha-ayin*], for he has no connection or hold on the truth”; and the *erev rav* whom the cloud “spat out” had “some connection to the nations.” This illuminates the se’if: the nations’ forward-healing “is not an enduring healing,” for their hold — like Amalek’s — is merely external, with no grip on the inner truth, whereas Israel’s root is “truly good.”

43 R’ Tzadok — parallel (Poked Akarim §4): “All the creation of the world is for the sake of man, to serve in it and bring forth its abundance; [and] this too was blurred and spoiled through what people spoiled in their deeds. But ‘your people are all righteous — forever they shall inherit the land’ (Yeshayah 60:21): an eternal inheritance that has no cessation or spoiling — for they are called ‘the remnant of Yosef.’” This is the se’if’s contrast: Israel’s healing is *enduring* (“an inheritance with no cessation”), whereas the nations’ forward-healing is destined to reopen.

— **And the root of Avraham Avinu was aroused through this to heal, at least going forward, the entire world.** אף דלעגן רפואה דלהבא גם כן יש חילוק בין ישראל לאמות העולם, דאצלים אינה רפואה המתקיימת כלל, ובבירור סוף המכה לחזור ולהתגלות — **though even regarding forward-healing there is a difference between Israel and the nations: for with them it is not an enduring healing at all, and it is clear that in the end the wound is destined to return and reappear; and whereas Israel — “your people are all righteous” (Yeshayah 60:21)⁴⁴ — one is at once called a complete tzaddik, so that “the path of the righteous is like the light of dawn, growing ever brighter” (Mishlei 4:18); for the initial stirring of a thought of teshuvah in the heart takes effect to go on increasing.** אבל דבר זה הוא מצד מדרגות העמידות; אבל מדרגה זו דתשובה — **But that [ever-brightening] belongs to the future rungs; whereas this rung of teshuvah — healing-going-forward, for the past alone — this embraces the entire world.**

סעיף 6 — Se'if 6

The theme: This is the middah of *Chesed*, which is expansion — and it reaches forward only. Forgiveness from *Chesed* presupposes that a sin exists and is pardoned, so a residue of shame remains. To be as though one had never sinned is impossible from this side: *Chesed* is expansion without force, and the heart's first stirring is broad but not yet strong.

וזהו מדת החסד שהוא בהתפשטות [ומדת “גורב חסד” הוא ריבוי יותר, דנושא עון גם בלא תשובה, עיין [ב]הרי”ף פקק קמא דראש השנה; וגם שם מכל מקום עון עצמו אינו נמחק, דתנא דבי ר’ ישמעאל “מעביר ראשון — **And this is the middah of Chesed, which is “expansion” [and the middah of “and abounding in kindness” is a yet greater abundance, that bears sin even without teshuvah — see the Rif, first chapter of Rosh Hashanah; yet there too the sin itself is not erased, for the school of R’ Yishmael [taught] “He passes over the first [sins], one by one”].⁴⁵** ומכל מקום אינו אלא

44 **Yeshayah 60:21:** “And your people, all of them righteous, shall inherit the land forever; the branch of My planting, the work of My hands, in which I take glory.” From Yeshayah’s prophecy of the future redemption of Tzion (ch. 60). R’ Tzadok cites it to contrast Israel with the nations: because at their root “your people are all righteous,” a Jew is called a complete tzaddik the instant the stirring of teshuvah begins. **Rashi** (on *lehispa’er*): “that I shall take glory in them.” And the Mishnah (**Sanhedrin 90a**, Perek Chelek) makes this verse the proof-text that “all Israel have a share in the World to Come, as it is said, ‘and your people are all righteous, they shall inherit the land forever.’” The phrase “ועמך כולם צדיקים” receives a striking Chassidic complement in Tanya ch. 2. If the neshama of Israel is “chelek Eloka mima’al mamash,” then the prophetic designation “all of your people are righteous” can be read as a statement about root-identity rather than a denial of actual transgression. The revealed personality can become entangled in sin, while the second, Divine soul remains the inner source to which teshuvah returns. Sefas Emes, Rosh HaShanah 25:4, expresses the same distinction in terms of two loves. There is an ahavah awakened by mitzvos and good deeds, and there is the essential love of Israel rooted in “chelek Hashem amo,” which is not dependent on a particular deed and cannot be extinguished by “many waters.” Sin obscures the manifestation of the neshama; teshuvah causes it to awaken again. Thus R’ Tzadok’s use of “ועמך כולם צדיקים” is not sentimental: it is the ontological premise that allows teshuvah to uncover a righteousness deeper than the historical act.

45 **Rif, Rosh Hashanah (17a in the Rif; on the Thirteen Attributes):** “‘Bearing iniquity and passing over transgression’ — the school of R’ Yishmael taught: He passes over the first [sins], one by one [and does not reckon them]; and such is His measure.” The Gemara adds (Rava): “but the sin itself is not erased — for if his

אֲלֵא דְמַכּל מְקוֹם יֵשׁ בְּהִשָּׁה עֲדִיין, וְכִמוּ בְּבִגְי אָדָם אִי אֶשְׁמַח לּוֹ, כִּל זְמַן שְׁמֹכִירִים לוֹ מִתְבַּיֵּשׁ מִזֶּה; וְדָבָר — שִׁיָּהָה כְּאֵלּוּ לֹא חָטָא מַעֲוֹלָם, זֶה אִי אֶפְשָׁר כְּשֶׁהִסְלִיחָה מִצַּד מִדַּת הַחֶסֶד, וְכֵן כְּשֶׁהִתְשׁוּבָה מִצַּד אוֹתָהּ מִיָּדָה — **only that shame still remains — as with people, even though [one's fellow] pardoned him, whenever they remind him of it he is ashamed by it; and this — that it be as if he had never sinned at all — is impossible when the forgiveness is from the side of the middah of Chesed, and likewise when the teshuvah is from that same middah.**⁴⁷ — גְּדוּלָה וְגִבּוּרָה — פִּי הֵם שְׁתֵּי מִדּוֹת — שִׁיָּהָה שְׁנֵי הַפְּכִים; וְ"גְּדוּלָה" הוּא הִתְפַּשְׁטוּת בְּגִדְל, אָבֵל אֵינּוּ בְּגִבּוּרָה; וְהִתְחַלֵּת כִּל עֲגִינָה הוּא בְּהִתְפַּשְׁטוּת, וְאַחֲרֵי שִׁיָּהָה שְׁנֵי הַפְּכִים; וְ"גְּדוּלָה" הוּא הִתְפַּשְׁטוּת בְּגִדְל, אָבֵל אֵינּוּ בְּגִבּוּרָה; וְהִתְחַלֵּת כִּל עֲגִינָה הוּא בְּהִתְפַּשְׁטוּת, וְאַחֲרֵי שִׁיָּהָה שְׁנֵי הַפְּכִים; — **For they are two middos — Gedulah [Chesed] and Gevurah — which are two opposites; and Gedulah is expansion in magnitude but not in force; and the beginning of every matter is in expansion, and afterward it begins to intensify, and then the expansion contracts through the intensification.**⁴⁸ — וְכֵן הִתְחַלֵּת — הִרְהוּר הַתְּשׁוּבָה בְּלֵב אָדָם שְׁאֵינּוּ עֲדִיין בְּגִבּוּרָת הַלֵּב בְּכַח אֲמִיץ וְחֹזֶק שְׁלֵא יִנְתַּק, אַע"פ שֶׁהוּא בְּהִתְפַּשְׁטוּת יוֹתֵר, — **So too the beginning of a thought of teshuvah in a person's heart, which is not yet in the strength of the heart, in a firm, powerful force that will not snap — although it is more expansive, nonetheless its power is not yet so**

46 Yoma 87a: “One who seeks pardon from his fellow need not ask more than three times” (for that suffices as appeasement). R’ Tzadok: a fortiori before God, whose kindness is boundless — the slightest remorse and a light request (“forgive us”) bring immediate pardon; yet this *Chesed*-forgiveness still leaves residual “shame,” which only the higher, *Gevurah*-rooted teshuvah (the coming simanim) removes.

48 R' Tzadok — **parallel (Yisrael Kedoshim §4):** “This is [Avraham’s] grip on the middah of *Chesed* — which is the perfection of all his desires in holiness, for the sake of Heaven, as they said, ‘a man’s desire is his *chesed*’; and therefore they said of him that he did not [even] neglect his marital obligation, for he had no other intent but the mitzvah.” The se’if’s *Chesed* is “expansion” — Avraham’s boundless outpouring; its very expansiveness is why, at teshuvah’s beginning, it heals “going forward” but has not yet the contracting *force* of *Gevurah*.

strong, and therefore it brings only forward-healing; דמנה לא ימלט אפילו תשובה הייתה קלה, ומיד — **for from this not even the lightest teshuvah is exempt, and immediately at its beginning — this is its “greatness.”**⁴⁹

49 R' Tzadok — parallel (Tzidkas HaTzadik §40): “The essence of teshuvah is until Hashem *enlightens his eyes*, that the willful sins become as merits — that he recognize and grasp that all he sinned was *also* by the will of Hashem” (as in Berachos 31b, and the Arizal’s reconciling of foreknowledge and free choice, “both true, each in its own domain”); “and when he attains this immense light, then all his willful sins are turned [to merits].” This is the crown of the rung §1-6 opens toward: not the *Chesed* that pardons yet leaves shame, but the *Gevurah*-born light in which the past itself is re-read as Divine guidance — the “as if he had never sinned,” and beyond. Izhbitz-Radzin on yedi’ah and bechirah — and the boundary that prevents this doctrine from becoming an excuse for sin. Mei HaShiloach, Vayeilech 3, says that even though bechirah is given into human hands, one who sees deeply recognizes that human action is "רק דבר מונע כקליפת השום" relative to the encompassing Divine conduct. In Tazria 2 he can say simultaneously that a person’s eventual attainment was prepared from the beginning of creation and, nevertheless, "מצד האדם יש לו בחירה." The two statements are intentionally held together: from the creature’s lived standpoint, command, responsibility, restraint, and teshuvah are real; from the later Divine illumination, the person may discover a providential depth that was never visible at the moment of choice. This is the key to R’ Tzadok’s use of the Arizal’s yedi’ah/bechirah resolution and his statement that, at the highest teshuvah, a person can recognize that "all he sinned was also by the will of Hashem." The recognition belongs to the **afterward** of teshuvah — "until Hashem enlightens his eyes" — not to the beforehand of temptation. Mei HaShiloach, Devarim 2, sometimes reads the Torah’s naming of places of Israel’s sins as teaching that circumstances and spiritual "place" can radically narrow a person’s field of choice. But Beis Yaakov, Bereshis 69:1, supplies the essential guardrail through its reading of Cain. Cain’s "השומר אחי אנכי" is understood as the claim that overwhelming anger had removed his bechirah and therefore he should not be liable. The Divine answer rejects the self-exculpation: "קול דמי אחיר צועקים" proves that the deficiency is attributed to Cain and that he had a point of responsibility by which he could have guarded himself. The Ishbitz doctrine therefore works in two directions at once. Before and during action, a Jew must regard himself as a baal bechirah, obey Torah, resist the yetzer, and never invoke hidden providence to legitimate a prohibited act. After a genuine teshuvah that has uprooted identification with the sin, Hashem may reveal a deeper yedi’ah: the fall itself can be integrated into a providential road by which the person came to a higher recognition. That latter illumination is what R’ Tzadok associates with zedonos becoming zechuyos. It does not say the aveirah was permitted; it says that Divine omnipotence can reclaim even the prohibited past and make the **teshuvah born from it** part of the final good. This is the precise Izhbitz-Radzin frame in which the radical sentence of Tzidkas HaTzadik §40 should be read.

תְּקִנַּת הַשָּׁבִין

Takanas HaShavin

Siman 2

סִימָן ב

Great is teshuvah, for it reaches the Throne of Glory

גְּדוּלָה תְּשׁוּבָה שֶׁמִּגַּעַת עַד כִּסֵּא הַכְּבוֹד.